private areas with gates (formal or informal) controlled by the residents; so visitors to the Taj would have been familiar with the concept of moving inwards from the hustle and bustle of the bazaar to the more private realm[27].

The Formal Gardens (Charbagh)

Through the Great Gate, visitors enter one of the most spectacular landscapes on earth: the Gardens of the Taj Mahal. Unlike many famous monuments, such as the Eiffel Tower or the Pyramids of Giza, the Taj Mahal is largely hidden from view and does not dominate the city's landscape. Instead, it is withdrawn inside the walls like a precious gem and is only finally revealed to visitors once they pass through the Great Gate.

Observers stand on a raised stone platform that continues along the perimeter wall, giving a sense that the garden is sunken and giving further drama to the mausoleum rising up in the distance. The garden itself is square, with four paths and pools of water coming in from each of the gates. Also in front of the gate is a long reflecting pool which continually draws the eyes towards the mausoleum. In the very center of the garden, the spot where traditionally one would find the tomb in earlier Mughal garden tombs, is a central fountain. The gardens themselves are perfectly manicured and symmetrical, with lines of shrubbery and trees flanking the approach to the Mausoleum.